

The Illusion of Choice: Weaponized Debt, Asymmetrical Power, and structural coercion

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International labor migration is often framed as a dichotomy between voluntary economic opportunity and forced displacement. Yet this binary obscures the systemic forces that shape migrants' "choices" and experiences. International labor migration is shaped by structural forces that systematically exploit migrants' vulnerabilities. While these systems constrain agency, migrants resist through informal networks and knowledge-sharing, challenging the very binaries that justify their marginalization. This essay analyzes how structural actors - states, brokers, and global labor markets - exploit migrants through debt, legal precarity, and racialized hierarchies, while migrants navigate these constraints through resilience and collective agency. The works of Killias (2009), Rodrigues (2010), and Ruhs (2013) provide critical lenses for this analysis: Killias exposes how recruitment systems trap migrants in modern bondage; Rodrigues reveals state complicity in commodifying workers; and Ruhs reframes migration as a tradeoff between rights

and wages, highlighting the paradox of “voluntary” exploitation. In the paper, I first deconstruct this voluntary/forced binary, demonstrating how debt and state policies coercively shape migration decisions. Then, I examine the role of brokers and labor brokerage states in normalizing exploitation, before analyzing the precarious conditions migrants face and their strategies of resistance. Ultimately, I argue that migrant agency, expressed through knowledge-sharing and informal networks, subverts the very systems designed to control them.

Firstly, I examine the dynamics between the voluntary and forced migration binary. A first distinction must be made to comprehend the situation of migrants: their exact status. We could argue that forced migration happens when catastrophes such as war, climate related phenomenon or political discrimination compel individuals to leave their home to find better (if not basic) living conditions. On the other hand, voluntary migrations could encapsulate cases where individuals chose to leave their country in search of something they can only find elsewhere: mostly better wages. An example of this would be Indonesian women, who “migrate voluntarily due to gendered labor demands” (Killias 2009). However, as Rodrigues (2010) points out, there is a significant intersectionality between these categories. Where do individuals fleeing an economic crisis fall? How about those who willingly join human trafficking schemes to survive? Conceptualizing this as a spectrum is more accurate, with each migrant making decisions based on a tradeoff unique to their situation. These “choices” made by migrants are often coerced by structural forces: “voluntary” migration, as we will uncover throughout this paper, is engineered by states and brokers as a necessity. Davidson argues that “migration through debt is not voluntary” (Davidson 2013), and that state policies produce migrant indebtedness. Additionally, a migrant’s legal

situation will impact its earnings, as employers adjust wages and skill level of the work according to the legal status of the workers they employ (Ruhs 2013). While the voluntary/forced binary highlights the complexity of migrant decision-making, the role of brokers and states further complicates this dynamic by controlling access to migration pathways and information.

Secondly, migrants can most often not achieve their journey alone and must rely on specialized actors to both reach their destination and find employment. Recruiters are often the dominant pathway through which migrants obtain work visas, and they pay them significant fees to do so, leading to a cycle of debt (Killias 2009). Indebtedness is used as a tool of control, and forms a modern-day bondage for private brokers to informally manage migrants. By ensuring that wage reduction systems and high interest rates keep migrants in the cycle of debt, brokers profit off of them even after their input is no longer necessary. Under the pretext of economic development, brokers can safely conduct operations putting at risk the workers they send abroad, while encouraged by authorities: in Jakarta alone hundreds of recruitment branches conduct harsh psychological tests and accommodate for a few days potential overseas workers, mostly from remote rural villages and little access to international connections. The exploitation facilitated by brokers is often enabled or overlooked by state policies, which play a central role in shaping the structures of migration and labor precarity.

These agencies mentioned above are sometimes national institutions: labor brokerage states have a dedicated legislature that streamlines the processes of migration to standardize this process. These states are often low-income countries that rely on the remittances of emigrated

workers to support part of their population. Some governments, like the Agadez, Libyan, or Sahelian officials (Kah 2019), are dependent on migrant economies and will incentivize their population to undergo migration processes even if it is not in their best interest. Gaining profit from this, they have set up a legalized human traffic to maximize the export of “commodities” to countries they previously advertised their workers to. The Philippines for example “markets workers as obedient and hardworking” (Rodrigues 2010), participating in the production of a specific set of discourses on their migrants to create publicity. Much like brokers, labor brokerage states ensure their migrants are reliant on them by imposing legislature. Again in the Philippines, Executive Order 857 required overseas workers to send back at least 50% of their pay (70% for some professions), risking removal from eligible worker lists in case of non-compliance. This is especially problematic since the state formalized global labor transfers and uses its network of embassies and diplomatic connections to connect states with its workers, making them dependent on these contracts (Rodrigues 2010). Paradoxically, legislation tending to the rights of the migrants is systematically underdeveloped. Since crossing a border exposes migrants to a new authority, the freedom and living conditions they face are unpredictably variable.

Migrants face precarious work conditions. According to Ruhs (2013), the tradeoff between wage increase (compared to their home country) and the harsh new environment is often what determines the choice to migrate. Globally, a greater openness to low-skill migrants of a receiving country means reduced rights (Russ 2013). These policies are deliberate outcomes of state-broker alliances and directly connect the precarity of migrants to the financial decisions made by more powerful actors (multi-national firms, states, legislations). Indeed, a high-income country is influenced in its border policies by factors such as the housing market, levels of nationalism, costs

of social benefits and sectors in need of work force. These factors determine what profiles of migrant they look for, creating a hierarchy of desirability. On top of working conditions, the societal role of migrants undermines their abilities: a language of invisibility isolates them from other fringes of society, while an increased criminalization may escalate minor offenses into deportation. The threat of a forced removal shows the tangible outcome of migration: not only do immigration officers hold much power, but the victimization of migrants can be normalized. In Malaysia for example, Indonesian domestic workers face systemic abuse, and the media participates in the normalization of these practices by only reporting extreme cases of sexual abuse and silencing all others (Killias 2009). Despite these challenges, migrants demonstrate resilience and agency, using informal networks and knowledge-sharing to resist exploitation and navigate precarious conditions.

The vulnerability of migrants is largely due to their reliance on external actors to undergo migration processes. There is not much a choice to make when everything is arranged for the worker, and weight options is not possible when there is only one way to find labor. That is why migrant agency and knowledge resistance is primordial to work towards better conditions. Migrants can empower themselves and their peers through civil society knowledge-sharing. Indeed, the visibility earned this way enables individuals to make informed choices about their migrating options. Narrowing down the uncertainty of the human rights versus the wage (or admission) trade off helps migrants make decisions that will more effectively benefit them (Ruhs 2013). This notion directly connects migrant knowledge and Amartya Sen's capability approach to human development: "As human development is defined as enlarging choice, capabilities, and freedoms, we can generally expect that the economic, social, political, and cultural rights that

migrants effectively enjoy will have a positive impact on their human development” (Ruhs 2013). Reversing this, knowing what conditions are necessary to enjoy these rights enables migrants to make choices that will place them in situation positively impacting their human development.

In conclusion, framing migration through a forced/voluntary binary distorts the systemic coercion underpinning migrant “choices,” as structural actors weaponize debt, legal precarity, and racialized hierarchies to extract labor while evading accountability. Killias, Rodrigues, and Ruhs collectively expose how states and brokers engineer migration as a necessity, trapping workers in cycles of exploitation masked as economic opportunity. Yet migrants’ resilience, expressed through informal networks and knowledge-sharing, subverts these systems: they reclaim agency within constrained conditions. Ultimately, this paper underscores that migration is neither freely chosen nor wholly imposed but shaped by asymmetrical power dynamics that commodify human mobility. We must strive to center migrant resistance as both a survival strategy and a critique of the global hierarchies that perpetuate their marginalization.

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